

in terms of tanks, planes, and artillery. On January 20, General Abrams asked Washington to authorize more airstrikes and extend US air support for the ARVN, including into Laos.

“The day after the election ... we will **bomb the bejeezus** out of them.”

RICHARD NIXON, NOVEMBER 20, 1971



Final preparations

Nixon meets with bipartisan Congressional leaders in the White House Cabinet Room on February 17, 1972, to discuss his upcoming trip to China. That afternoon, he left for Hawaii, where he would stay for four days before flying west.

Warning the public

On January 25, the president went on national television to prepare the public for what might unfold. His speech revealed the secret peace negotiations that had been taking place with the North Vietnamese, including a peace proposal presented to them in the previous October. He stated that if this proposal was rejected, he would take action to defend the remaining personnel in Vietnam.

By the end of January, the president had confirmed General Abrams's requests, and airstrikes were stepped up against the Ho Chi Minh Trail in Laos. Planners studied the intersections, choke points, and river crossings of the Trail, designating “blocking belts”—strategic points that when destroyed made escape difficult—and laying electronic sensors to provide target intelligence. The US also added to the Seventh Fleet in the South China Sea, and began preparations to operate B-52 bombers from the island of Guam and from Thailand.